

Section C (45 marks)

A research-based essay in French (240-270 words) rewards students for French-language research skills linked to an area of interest to the student. **This must relate to the culture and/or society of a French-language country, countries or community.** Students will need to draw on their knowledge and understanding of this. They will have freedom to determine the content of their research (potentially in negotiation with their teacher) but it must relate to one of the following areas of research:

- a Geographical area
- b Historical study
- c Aspects of modern society
- d Literature and the arts (eg text, play or film).

A question will be set for each of these four areas of research.

All students for this unit will be assessed by Edexcel.

Students are not permitted to take any books, dictionaries or texts into the examination room.

Preparation

It is anticipated that students will acquire essay writing and translation skills through regular classroom practice.

For the research-based essay, students should choose a text, play, film or topic area that they find particularly stimulating and that links to in-depth French-language study undertaken prior to the examination. They are free to choose and may discuss potential areas of research with their teacher. The research must relate to the culture and/or society of a French-language country, countries or community. More guidance is given in the *GCE research-based essay guide*. For more information on this please visit the Edexcel website (www.edexcel.org.uk).

Effective preparation for this unit must include study of different French-language spoken materials in addition to other printed and ICT-derived resources.

Time allocation

Students will be in control of the pace of assessment within the allocated time. They can answer questions in any order.

The duration of this examination will be 2 hours and 30 minutes.

4.3 Content

General topic areas

The assessment materials used will draw upon the following general topic areas:

- Youth culture and concerns
- Lifestyle: health and fitness
- The world around us: travel, tourism, environmental issues and the French-speaking world
- Education and employment
- Customs, traditions, beliefs and religions
- National and international events: past, present and future
- Literature and the arts.

Research-based essay

Edexcel recognises that it is logical, motivating and rewarding for advanced-level French-language students to acquire knowledge and develop understanding of different aspects of the culture and/or society of a French-speaking country or countries. This unit features a research-based essay directly linked to the culture and/or society of a French-language country, countries or community.

The research-based essay offers teachers a logical and smooth transition from either coursework or the 'topics and texts' option. It also encourages wide reading, creativity and personal initiative. Students have a choice of content and focus so that they are able to present and summarise their research from their own personal perspective. The essay must reflect their views and opinions and have an analytical or evaluative dimension commensurate with advanced-level study. The research-based essay should appeal to a variety of students — those interested in literature and the arts as well as those preferring non-literary areas of research.

The following outlines four possible areas of research that students can choose from and the required content.

Geographical area (eg region or city)

Students would be expected to undertake wide research, become aware of and demonstrate understanding of the following:

- key people, events and issues (eg demographic, environmental, economic, social, political) that have impacted or are having an impact on the area
- customs, traditions, beliefs and religions.

Historical study

Students would be expected to undertake wide research, consider and demonstrate understanding of the following:

- a specific period of history of particular relevance to the chosen country
- key people, events and issues from the above period.

Aspects of modern French-speaking society

Students would be expected to undertake wide research, consider and demonstrate understanding of the following:

- key current and recent (21st century/late 20th century) events and issues (eg social, cultural and political) and their impact on society.

Literature and the arts

Students would be expected to undertake in-depth study of a substantial French-language **text**, **play** or **film**. They would need to consider and demonstrate understanding of the following:

- different characters
- key themes/issues
- social and cultural setting
- styles/techniques employed.

In each of these four areas, students are expected to analyse the research that they have undertaken, give their opinions and justify them. This provides a logical link to the approach adopted in Unit 3.

During the research phase, students should refer to a variety of resources including textbooks, reference books, the internet, audio-visual media etc. Students will be expected to make appropriate references to specific French-language sources that they have consulted. More information and guidance is given in the *GCE research-based essay guide*.

What students need to learn

Students need to develop language skills that enable them to transfer meaning from English into French, communicate effectively, accurately and confidently in French-language writing, and demonstrate French-language research skills linked to a specific aspect of the society and/or the culture of a French-language country, countries or community.

Students will be expected to demonstrate knowledge and understanding of the grammar and structures as prescribed in *Appendix 6: Grammar lists*.